Additionally, there are many areas where the US president's power is more rhetorical than real. For all the talk of slashing budgets, entire government agencies and policies, the executive branch is dependent upon or hamstrung by the US Congress, which controls purse strings, and the judiciary, which can stop policies and rules from being implemented. One area where the president can actually exert a great deal of influence over is immigration—the topic that contributed perhaps the most to Trump's 2016 and 2024 victories and where we may see immediate changes. We are no more likely to see the building of border walls paid for by Mexico (or Canada) than we were in the first Trump presidency, but we might reasonably assume other types of immigration changes to be enacted—some more quickly than others. There are three I believe will be of significance to Indian immigrants and Indian Americans: harsher enforcement of immigration regulations, constraints upon work-based immigration, and limitations for international students.

In the first instance, Trump has campaigned on creating and maintaining a more punitive immigration regime, starting with what he calls mass deportations from Day 1 of his presidency, a suspension or elimination of refugee resettlement, and a narrowing of other legal immigration pathways. It remains to be seen how many of these will actually be fulfilled—large sectors of the US economy would be crippled if deprived of the labour of undocumented workers, for example. Yet for Indian migrants crossing both the northern and southern US borders in greater numbers in the past decade, the threat of harsher treatment will manifest quickly, in the form of swift deportations and swifter denials of asylum claims. Indian nationals have been among the most rapidly growing number of undocumented immigrants in the US. This is true not only at the southern border, which has historically had the far greater share of illegal entries to the US, but also in the northern border with Canada. In the Swanton sector, covering northern New York and Vermont, where I live, more than half of the illegal crossings into the US from Canada have been Indians, mostly young men, but a good number of families as well. A large proportion have been from Punjab, young people, many of them farmers, who have been displaced from their own homes and livelihoods due to both instability back home and the lure of opportunity in the US. That dream of a better life and prospects has drawn many others to try and cross the border into the US, sometimes resulting in tragic outcomes as with the Gujarati family that froze to death crossing the barren wasteland in the winter of 2022. Yet many continue to cross this border illegally; today, Indians account for 375,000 unauthorised immigrants in the US [according to a 2022 estimate. A 2023 PEW survey puts the figure at 725,000], the fifth largest group nationally. Their future under this new regime will become even more precarious.

UNAUTHORISED INDIAN IMMIGRANTS IN THE US MAY NOW **FACE SWIFT DEPORTATION AND DENIAL OF ASYLUM CLAIMS** UNDER A MORE PUNITIVE IMMIGRATION REGIME

Uncertain too will be the future of legal immigrants. One of the most popular pathways for educated immigrants since the 1990s has been the H-1B visa programme, which has provided a special entry to tech workers and others with advanced degrees. Trump has railed against family reunification and suggested that a skills-based immigration system ought to be prioritised in the US. Yet, during his first administration, it was the H-1B programme—the largest guest worker programme in the US—that was narrowed. In 2018, for example, 24 per cent of H-1B applications were denied, compared to just 2 per cent in 2022. The impact of the changes to the programme will disproportionately affect Indian nationals; in 2022, 73 per cent of applicants were Indian. The future of the H-1B programme has opened up deep fissures within Trump's winning coalition, with the anti-immigration wing wanting to once again restrict this pathway, and the tech industry and entrepreneurs arguing in favour of enlarging the programme. Trump himself has tentatively signalled his support for it; however, the debate continues to rage amongst his base, with Indian immigrants receiving a disproportionate share of the backlash.

A third group who may find migration to the US perilous are international students. Going by the 2016-2020 period, there will be more scrutiny of visa applications, fewer opportunities to work on and off campus, and less chances to stay after graduation. International students are a crucial component of any university campus, and Indian students currently number upward of 250,000 out of the 1 million-odd international students in the US. In the first Trump presidency, a narrowing of their opportunities and pathways meant that many turned to other destinations like Europe, Canada or Australia. Will a similar lack of foresight, understanding and knowledge threaten the opportunities for migrants—and receiving communities—again? ■

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